
BBC LEARNING ENGLISH

6 Minute English

Rude emails



This is not a word-for-word transcript.

Phil

Hello, this is 6 Minute English from BBC Learning English. I'm Phil.

Becca

And I'm Becca.

Phil

Sending emails is a big part of modern work, and most people try to write emails politely. Most, but not all! Recently, BBC Radio 4 programme All in the Mind asked listeners to tell them what they find rude in emails. Here, presenter Claudia Hammond and guest Pete Olusoga discuss what listeners had to say:

Claudia Hammond

Rachel in Manchester says what annoys her is people who start their emails with just your name and without a simple greeting like 'hi'. She says the unnecessary formality always has the effect of **putting her** immediately **on the defensive**.

Dr Peter Olusoga

We've got an anonymous one here, who recently received a single emoji in response to a carefully considered and worded email.

Becca

One listener doesn't like emails which start with just her name because they **put her on the defensive**. The phrase to **put someone on the defensive** means to do or say something which makes them feel threatened or unsure.

Phil

Another listener found it rude when their email was answered with a single emoji, and I think that would annoy me too. These emails are examples of people being **uncivil** – an adjective meaning rude or impolite. And just to note, the noun that goes with this is **incivility**. In this episode, we'll be hearing more about rude emails

at work and, as usual, we'll be learning some useful new vocabulary, all of which you can find on our website, [bbclearningenglish.com](https://www.bbc.com/learningenglish).

Becca

But first, I have a question for you, Phil. Last year, thousands of US government workers received an email requiring them to justify their job by listing five things they had accomplished that week... or resign. But who sent this email? Was it:

- a) Donald Trump,
- b) JD Vance, or
- c) Elon Musk?

Phil

Ooh, I don't know... Maybe JD Vance?

Becca

We'll find out later in the programme. Now, according to some psychologists, rudeness in emails is based on a fight-or-flight response humans feel when stressed. Here, psychologist Dr Emma Russell explains these responses for BBC Radio 4's All in the Mind.

Dr Emma Russell

So, a fight response is usually when we try to dominate or **belittle** other people. Emails that are hostile in tone and language, or even cc'ing senior personnel in on the message in order to elevate an issue and **put someone in their place**. Then the flight response is when people try to protect themselves by withdrawing or avoiding. They won't reply, or if they do reply, maybe they don't answer all of the points in the email. They're just trying to **get it off their plate**.

Phil

The fight response can make us **belittle** someone – make them feel inferior or unimportant. For example, a boss sends a group email in which they give someone else the credit for the work you did. The boss wants to **put you in your place** – an idiom meaning to show someone that they are less important than they think they are.

Becca

The flight response, meanwhile, can be seen when co-workers ignore your message or give a quick, unhelpful reply. Such colleagues want to **get work off their plate** – another idiom, meaning to remove tasks from your own workload and give them to someone else to deal with.

Phil

Unfortunately, when stressed and working to a deadline it's hard to make sure all your emails are polite. That's what Emma Russell said when she spoke to BBC Radio 4's All in the Mind.

Dr Emma Russell

Because we're operating in these environments where we are all quite **frazzled**, we are more at risk of engaging in **incivility**.

Becca

We're more likely to be **uncivil** when we're **frazzled** – an informal adjective describing feeling tired or anxious because you're doing too many things at the same time.

Phil

Luckily, there are ways to help. If you feel angry when writing an email, pause before you hit send. One day it might save your friendship or even your job! OK. Becca, I'm going to politely ask you to please reveal the answer to your question.

Becca

Of course, Phil. I asked you who sent the email requiring workers to justify their employment or resign.

Phil

I said that I thought it might have been JD Vance.

Becca

Well, we're not going to fire you, Phil, but you are wrong. The correct answer was Elon Musk. OK. Let's recap the vocabulary we've learnt, starting with the idiom **put someone on the defensive**, meaning to make someone feel threatened or unsure.

Phil

The adjective **uncivil** means impolite, and we have a similar noun that's **incivility**.

Becca

To **belittle** someone means to make them feel inferior or unimportant.

Phil

If you **put someone in their place**, you show them that they're not as important as they think they are.

Becca

To **get something off your plate** means to give someone else a task or problem instead of dealing with it yourself.

Phil

And finally, if you're **frazzled**, you feel tired or anxious because you're doing too much. Once again, our six minutes are up.

Becca

If you want to know more about communication at work, check out our series Office English.

Phil

It's on our website, along with a quiz and a worksheet for this episode, and that's bbclearningenglish.com. But now it's goodbye.

Becca

Bye!

VOCABULARY

put (someone) on the defensive

(idiom) make someone feel unsure or threatened by what you do or say

uncivil

not polite; rude

belittle

make someone feel inferior or not important

put (someone) in their place

(idiom) show or tell someone that they are less important or clever than they think they are

get (something) off your plate

(idiom) pass a task or problem from your workload to someone else for them to deal with

frazzled

tired, nervous or anxious because you have to do too many things at the same time